CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

BOAT RESTORATION / FLIPPING IN THE AI ERA

Neglected boats are cheap for a reason — your skills turn somebody's abandoned dream into somebody else's summer.

★ **TL;DR — Around $75K a year for a restorer who keeps projects moving, startable in 1–6 months. The catch: boats hide rot like houses hide plumbing — the survey you skip is the profit you lose.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

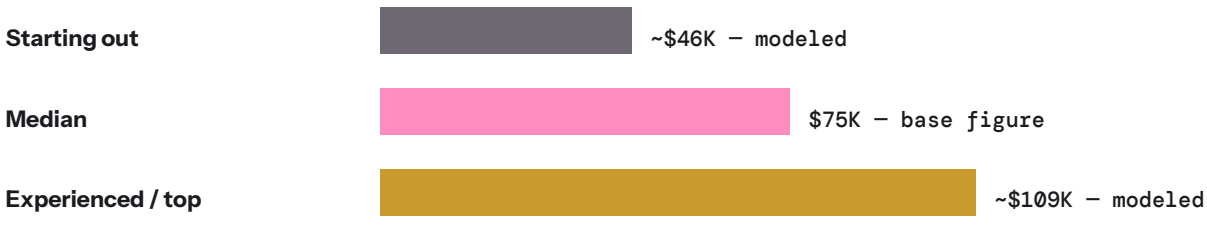
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW

- Neglected boats sell for a fraction of clean ones; the gap is labor, knowledge and nerve.
- Trailers, titles and storage decide deals as much as hulls do — the logistics are the business.
- Every finished boat markets the next one: marinas are small worlds with long memories.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Boat Restoration / Flipping is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A BOAT RESTORATION / FLIPPING ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Hunt undervalued boats: marina yards, estate sales, abandoned-project listings
- ✓ Inspect hulls, stringers, engines and electrics — or pay someone who can, before money moves
- ✓ Restore: fiberglass, gelcoat, upholstery, rigging, engine service, detailing
- ✓ Photograph, list and sea-trial the finished boat with buyers

Think: house flipping, except the house floats, the basement is the bilge, and neglect sinks faster.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI scans listings across regions, estimates market values and drafts sales copy. Price discovery that took weekends now takes an hour.	The tap-test on a hull stays human: hearing the dead spot in fiberglass, smelling fuel in the bilge, judging whether an old engine is tired or just neglected. Resale buyers pay for your eye and your honesty.

⚠ **Rotten stringers and dead engines hide under fresh paint and good photos — cosmetic flips on boats are dangerous, not just unprofitable. Storage and marina fees also charge rent to your project every single month it sits.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Work outdoors, on the water, with your hands ✓ Transformations you can photograph from space ✓ A skill set that doubles as your own boating life	✗ Fiberglass dust, bottom paint and old fuel are the uniform ✗ Projects stretch — weather, parts and surprises conspire ✗ Storage fees tax every week of optimism

Good fit? A marine-hands person who can judge hulls and engines honestly, price labor like a business and finish projects before buying the next one.
Bad fit? You fall for every cheap hull with a story, or you have never priced what storage, parts and your own weekends cost.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — SMALL TRAILER BOATS FIRST	DOOR B — THE ABANDONED PROJECT BOAT

The sane entry: trailerable outboard boats you can store at home, work on in the driveway and sell to the biggest buyer pool there is. Small money per deal, fast lessons, no marina meter running.	Bigger cruisers and sailboats sold mid-restoration for pennies. Bigger upside, bigger risk: surveys, systems and months of work. Enter only with the skills — or the paid experts — to judge what 'almost done' really means.

Smart move: Buy the boat with the clean title and the good trailer. Beginners chase hulls; pros know paperwork and transport problems eat more deals than bad gelcoat ever will.
Where you land after: A reputation as the person who brings boats back — then restoration commissions from owners, not just flips of your own.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
LEARN WHAT	SET UP	INSPECT LIKE	BUY ONE,	RESTORE TO	SELL WITH

STEP 1 — Learn what 'cheap' really costs

FREE · 2-3 WEEKS

- Study sold prices for the models you will target, and price the parts that always die: outboards, upholstery, floors, trailers.
- Walk marina yards and talk to owners — the education is standing right there, dusty.

STEP 2 — Set up the work base

$300-2,000 · 2-4 WEEKS

- Secure legal workspace and storage you can afford monthly — your own yard beats a marina bill.
- Register the business and sort sales paperwork: titles and registration transfer rules for boats in your state.

STEP 3 — Inspect like a buyer of problems

FREE-$300 · PER BOAT

- Moisture meter, compression test, bilge and stringer checks — or hire a surveyor for anything beyond small money.
- Write the full repair list and price it before offering. If the seller's story and the boat disagree, believe the boat.

STEP 4 — Buy one, finish one

CAPITAL · MONTHS 1-4

- Start with the trailer boat you can complete in weeks, not the cruiser that takes a season.
- Document everything with photos — the restoration album is half your sales pitch.

STEP 5 — Restore to safe and clean, not perfect

PARTS BUDGET · 4-10 WEEKS

- Structure, engine, safety gear and cosmetics buyers can see — in that order.
- Track parts and hours like a job, because it is one: your hourly rate at sale time is the truth.

STEP 6 — Sell with proof

PAID · 1-3 WEEKS

- Cold-start video, sea-trial footage, the restoration album and a clean title in hand.
- Price from sold comparable boats, not from your effort — the market pays for the boat, not your weekends.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- Today: pick your target class of boat and study twenty sold listings until prices feel familiar.
- Days 1–30: set up workspace and paperwork, walk yards, inspect three cheap boats without buying any.
- Days 31–60: buy the first small project with a written repair budget — and start work the same week.
- Days 61–90: finish, document and list the first restoration; log your true hourly earnings honestly.
- Day 90: one boat sold (or nearly) and a real number for what your labor earns. Scale only if the number respects you.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **BELIEVE THE BOAT, NOT THE STORY.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.